

PSC 201

The Fact of Democratic Peace

Bruce Russett

We have no quarrel with the German people. . . . It was not upon their impulse that their government acted in entering this war. It was not with their previous knowledge or approval. It was a war determined upon as wars used to be determined upon in the old unhappy days when peoples were nowhere consulted by their rulers and wars were provoked and waged in the interest of dynasties or of little groups of ambitious men who were accustomed to use their fellow men as pawns and tools. Self-governed nations do not fill their neighbor states with spies or set the course of intrigue to bring about some critical posture of affairs which will give them an opportunity to strike and make conquest. . . . Cunningly contrived plans of deception or aggression, carried, it may be from generation to generation, can be worked out and kept from the light only within the privacy of courts or behind the carefully guarded confidences of a narrow and privileged class.

—Woodrow Wilson's war message to Congress,
April 2, 1917

275
Scholars and leaders now commonly say "Democracies almost never fight each other." What does that mean? Is it true? If so, what does it imply for the future of international politics? Would the continued advance of democracy introduce an era of relative world peace? Can policymakers act so as to make that kind of peaceful world more likely, and, if so, how? Does the post-Cold War era represent merely the passing of a particular adversarial relationship, or does it offer a chance for fundamentally changed relations among nations?

During the Cold War, Soviet-American hostility was overdetermined. The very different political systems of the two superpowers, with their built-in ideological conflict, ensured a deadly political and military rivalry. So too did the systemic stresses of two great powers, each leading a big alliance in a bipolar confrontation, which ensured that each would resist any enhancement of the other's strength as a threat to its own security. But the end of the Cold War destroyed both those sources of hostility. The ideological conflict dissolved with the end of communism, and the bipolar confrontation collapsed with that of the Soviet alliance system and of the Soviet Union itself. Given the revolutionary changes both in the global system and in the states that comprise it, the old bases for evaluating the character of international relations have also collapsed.

The end of ideological hostility matters doubly because it represents a surrender to the force of Western values of economic and especially political

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The Fact of Democratic Peace | 59

freedom. To the degree that countries once ruled by autocratic systems become democratic, a striking fact about the world comes to bear on any discussion of the future of international relations: in the modern international system, democracies have almost never fought each other. This statement represents a complex phenomenon: (a) Democracies rarely fight each other (an empirical statement) because (b) they have other means of resolving conflicts between them and therefore do not need to fight each other (a prudential statement), and (c) they perceive that democracies should not fight each other (a normative statement about principles of right behavior), which reinforces the empirical statement. By this reasoning, the more democracies there are in the world, the fewer potential adversaries we and other democracies will have and the wider the zone of peace. This book will document, explain, and speculate about the implications of the phenomenon of democratic peace.

The vision of a peace among democratically governed states has long been invoked as part of a larger structure of institutions and practices to promote peace among nation-states. Immanuel Kant spoke of perpetual peace based partially upon states sharing "republican constitutions."¹ His meaning was compatible with basic contemporary understandings of democracy. As the elements of such a constitution he identified freedom (with legal equality of subjects), representative government, and separation of powers. The other key elements of his perpetual peace were "cosmopolitan law" embodying ties of international commerce and free trade, and a "pacific union" established by treaty in international law among republics.

Woodrow Wilson expressed the same vision for the twentieth century. This normative political basis of Wilson's vision of world order, evident as early as 1894, grew naturally from his progressive inclinations in domestic politics²; and his Fourteen Points sound almost as though Kant were guiding Wilson's writing hand. They included Kant's cosmopolitan law and pacific union. The third point demanded "the removal, so far as possible, of all economic barriers and the establishment of an equality of trade conditions among all the nations consenting to the peace and associating themselves for its maintenance"; and the fourteenth point called for "a general association of nations . . . formed under specific covenants for the purpose of affording mutual guarantees of political dependence and territorial integrity to great and small states alike." He did not so clearly invoke the need for universal democracy, since at that

1. Immanuel Kant, *Kant's Political Writings*, ed. Hans Reiss and trans. H.B. Nisbet (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1970).

2. Thomas J. Knock, *To End All Wars: Woodrow Wilson and the Quest for a New World Order* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1992), pp. 9ff.

time not all of America's war allies were democracies. But the suggestion of this principle is clear enough if one thinks about the domestic political conditions necessary for his first point: "Open covenants of peace, openly arrived at, after which there shall be no private international understandings of any kind but diplomacy shall proceed always frankly and in the public view." Moreover, his 1917 war message openly asserted that "a steadfast concert of peace can never be maintained except by a partnership of democratic nations."

The Emergence of Democratic Peace before World War I

The strong norm that democracies should not fight each other seems to have developed only toward the end of the nineteenth century. That time period provides a number of examples in which stable democracies engaged in serious diplomatic disputes that took them to the brink of war, without ever actually going over the edge. In this restraint of action between democracies, and in the subsequent evaluations of the crises by the peoples and elites involved, we can discern some important differences between the expectations and norms operating among democracies and those that became operative when a democracy entered into an adversarial relationship with an authoritarian state.

During the 1890s Britain was engaged in a dispute with Venezuela over the boundary between that country and British Guiana. Grover Cleveland, the American president, grew exasperated by British unwillingness to submit the matter to arbitration and, invoking the Monroe Doctrine, threatened war. The British in turn took four months to reply—and then rejected the United States' position. Cleveland sought and obtained a congressional appropriation of funds for a boundary commission—in effect, enforced arbitration by the United States. In subsequent discussion, however, the United States offered to exclude from arbitration areas settled by British subjects for at least two generations, or sixty years. Charles Campbell says this "unexpected reversal virtually ensured an early termination of the controversy."³ With it the British in turn backed down, and agreed to arbitration that ultimately decided the issue by a compromise that generally favored Venezuela. In doing so, "Great Britain made almost all the concessions, and all the important ones"⁴; and the United States then pressured the Venezuelans to accept the decision.

3. Charles S. Campbell, *From Revolution to Rapprochement: The United States and Great Britain, 1783–1900* (New York: Wiley, 1974), p. 185.

4. A.E. Campbell, *Great Britain and the United States, 1895–1903* (London: Longmans, 1960), p. 27.

Clearly the British prime minister, Lord Salisbury, misjudged the American government's determination, and he was not willing to fight a war. Of Cleveland's intention we cannot be certain, but his actions look more like that of a poker player who expected his bluff to work, and not to be called. Both sides "blinked" in some degree—especially the British, at a time when their relations with Germany were deteriorating and they did not need another enemy.

Although important in preventing an Anglo-American war over this bagatelle, British strategic interests do not deserve all the credit for avoiding war. Stephen Rock, who has examined this and other international relationships during this time, has some illuminating comments on the public and official discourse. Describing the milieu of the Anglo-American relations—both during the crisis and over the next few years as the participants stepped back from the brink and considered what they might have done—he explains that "The reform bills of 1867 and 1884, which extended the franchise in England, had largely dissolved" the American image of England as feudal and aristocratic. "Anglo-Saxonism emerged as a major force" in relations between two nations toward the end of the nineteenth century, and burst forth in the war crisis. Feelings of Anglo-Saxon kinship contained strong elements of racialism and social Darwinism, but they held a serious political component as well. Richard Olney, Cleveland's secretary of state during the Venezuelan crisis, declared in 1896, "If there is anything they [Americans] are attached to, it is to ideals and principles which are distinctly English in their origin and development. . . . Nothing would more gratify the mass of the American people than to stand . . . shoulder to shoulder with England."⁵ Consider how different these sentiments were from what Americans were saying about Spain in 1898.

From the other side, British Colonial Secretary Joseph Chamberlain had already praised the "common laws and common standards of right and wrong" of the two countries. Later he declared that Americans' "laws, their literature, their standpoint on every question are the same as ours; their feeling, their interest, in the cause of humanity and the peaceful development of the world, are identical with ours." Arthur Balfour claimed that America's "laws, its language, its literature, and its religion, to say nothing of its constitution are essentially the same as those of English-speaking peoples elsewhere, [and] ought surely to produce a fundamental harmony—a permanent sympathy." According to Rock, this feeling of homogeneity of societal attributes

5. Stephen R. Rock, *Why Peace Breaks Out: Great Power Rapprochement in Historical Perspective* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1989), pp. 49–56.

lay behind the initial outpouring of pacifist sentiment during the Venezuelan boundary controversy and was a central element in popular and official desires for the settlement of that and other issues. . . . First, it colored the perceptions of both Englishmen and Americans, causing them to underestimate the importance of the conflict of geopolitical and economic interests between the two countries and to discount the significance of the concessions necessary to achieve an understanding. Second, it led many persons to conclude that the benefits of avoiding a fratricidal war with "racial" kin outweighed the costs of the sacrifices required for this to be accomplished.⁶

In effect, an Anglo-American security community was becoming established; "the last serious threat of war between the two powers passed."⁷ H. C. Allen concludes that "the British public never looked like accepting war, the American public after the first fine careless rapture drew back from the prospect of making it."⁸ In the Spanish-American war shortly thereafter, British sympathies were overwhelmingly with the United States.⁹

Meanwhile and subsequently, British and then American relations with Germany deteriorated, and ended ultimately in war. Paul Kennedy contrasts Britain's attitudes toward Germany with its new "special relationship" with the United States.¹⁰ Rock declares, "These effects were devastatingly absent—or reversed—in the Anglo-German and German-American cases."¹¹

While turn-of-the-century Britain was an industrial-capitalist, liberal, parliamentary democracy, imperial Germany was an autocratic, bureaucratic, authoritarian state. . . . These differences were appreciated, and even exaggerated, on both sides of the North Sea, and they colored the attitudes and perceptions of important segments of popular opinion as well as governmental leaders themselves. Englishmen, who could agree on practically nothing else, were in fact almost unanimous in their distaste for the German political system, its ideology, and its methods. . . . Both of these nations [Germany and the United States] were rising imperial powers with growing navies. Both threatened British interests in various regions of the globe. Yet Britons, while they detested and feared Germany, almost universally admired the United States and felt minimal apprehension at her ambitions. Part of this was geographic.

. . . But a large portion was ideological and cultural as well. Imbued as they were with a sense of Anglo-Saxon solidarity, the vast majority of Englishmen simply did not believe that Americans could wish or do them serious harm.¹²

The Fashoda crisis of 1898, however, which pitted Britain against France, poses a harder case. British and French interests had been advancing toward the Sudan, with Britain increasingly determined to control the area as protection for its major stake in Egypt. But French forces occupied the small fortress of Fashoda before the British could get there. When a much larger British force arrived, government leaders had to decide what to do. The French were in no position to fight. Their forces at Fashoda were far weaker, they had their hands full on the Continent with Germany, and Britain held unquestioned naval superiority. The premier, Théophile Delcassé, admitted that "the problem is how to combine the demands of honor with the necessity of avoiding a naval war which we are absolutely incapable of carrying through."¹³ Thus he offered compromise in several forms, ultimately offering to quit the area in return for commercial concessions. The British, however, would have none of it. They refused to negotiate so long as French forces were in the area, and the British prime minister, Lord Salisbury, seemed ready to go to war if the French would not concede totally. Ultimately they did.

The most recent scholarly work on the crisis concludes that "there is really no evidence in the archives in London and Paris that either government seriously considered going to war over Fashoda."¹⁴ The French gave in because of their military weakness and the need to avoid isolation in their far graver quarrel with Germany. In addition, their hand was weakened by governmental instability resulting from the Dreyfus affair.¹⁵ Salisbury wanted good relations with France to counter the growing threat he felt from Germany, and generally preferred diplomacy to force. In this crisis Salisbury was the poker player. He had to play a "two-level game"¹⁶ with imperialist hawks in domestic politics as well as with the French. While he might have been willing to fight if he had to, he did not want war and knew how weak the French really were.

6. Ibid., pp. 49–56.

7. Bruce Russett, *Community and Contention: Britain and America in the Twentieth Century* (Cambridge, Mass.: MIT Press, 1963), p. 5.

8. H.C. Allen, *Great Britain and the United States: A History of Anglo-American Relations (1783–1952)* (New York: St. Martin's, 1955), p. 540.

9. Charles S. Campbell, *Anglo-American Understanding, 1898–1903* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1957), chap. 2.

10. Paul Kennedy, *The Rise of Anglo-German Antagonism* (London: Allen and Unwin, 1980), esp. p. 399.

11. Rock, *Why Peace Breaks Out*, p. 56.

12. Ibid., pp. 86–87.

13. G.N. Sanderson, *England, Europe, and the Upper Nile, 1882–1899: A Study in the Partition of Africa* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 1965), p. 359.

14. Darrell Bates, *The Fashoda Incident of 1898: Encounter on the Nile* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1984), p. 153.

15. René Albrecht-Carrié, *Britain and France* (Garden City, N.Y.: Doubleday, 1970).

16. Robert Putnam, "Diplomacy and Domestic Politics: The Logic of Two-Level Games," *International Organization*, Vol. 42, No. 3 (Summer 1988), pp. 427–460.

Considerations of any norm that these two nations should not fight each other were well in the background on both sides; war was avoided primarily for other reasons. Nevertheless, sober reflection on the crisis brought the norms forward: "Both Britain and France possessed a commitment to liberalism and representative government and were opposed to autocracy and absolutism. During the period of reconciliation, numerous references were made to this effect, and to the role of this similarity in drawing the two countries together." A Liberal party leader, H. C. G. Matthew, said: "Most Liberals regarded the Entente with France as the natural result of common democratic impulses." Though they played little role in settling the crisis itself, these feelings were catalyzed by Fashoda and fed directly into the emerging Anglo-French entente.¹⁷

Thus the feeling of common liberal and democratic values played its part in moderating power conflicts between the United States and Britain, and Britain and France. Between the United States and Germany, on the other hand, the feelings were very different. The German and American political-economic systems involved "two essentially different conceptions of the state: that of the economically liberal laissez-faire state, in which one from the German side saw only disorder, egoism, and corruption, and the half-absolutist, neofeudalistic, bureaucratic state, which in American eyes destroyed the freedom of the individual and lacked democratic legitimation through the 'voice of the people.'"¹⁸ For Americans, an earlier vision of Germany became "replaced by the picture of an increasingly repressive, militaristic, authoritarian, and autocratic society."¹⁹ Such views were strengthened by the subsequent German war with Britain. Relationships based on type of political system reinforced strategic considerations. The ground was prepared for Wilson's vision of a world that could be at peace if and only if it were democratic.

The Spread of Democratic Peace

At the time of Kant, and even of Wilson, the hope for a world of democratic nation states was merely that: a hope, a theory perhaps, but without much

17. Rock, *Why Peace Breaks Out*, pp. 117–118.

18. Horst Christof, "Deutsch-amerikanische Entfremdung: Studien zu den deutsch-amerikanischen Beziehungen von 1913 bis zum Mai 1916" (Ph.D. dissertation, Julius-Maximilians-Universität, Würzburg, 1975), quoted in Rock, *Why Peace Breaks Out*, p. 141.

19. Rock, *Why Peace Breaks Out*, p. 143.

empirical referent. Certainly in Kant's time, Europe was hardly an area in which republics flourished. By the time of Wilson's Fourteen Points there were more, in the New World as well as the Old, but the dozen or so democracies of that time still were substantially in a minority.

Wilsonian "idealism" was widely regarded as discredited by the outbreak of World War II. True, the principles of collective security, as embodied in the League of Nations, failed to contain aggression by the Axis powers. In that sense, the element of international law in the Kantian and Wilsonian vision failed. But the elements of trade and democracy were never given a fair chance. International trade was damaged first by the imposition of war reparations on defeated Germany—with some of the effects forecast by John Maynard Keynes²⁰—and then by the round of "beggar my neighbor" trade restraints imposed with the collapse of the world economy in the Great Depression.²¹ Not coincidentally, democracy also was lost in many countries; first in Russia, then Italy, Germany, Central Europe, Japan, and elsewhere. Thus the Kantian prescription once again had little basis on which to work.

Largely unnoticed, however, was the empirical fact that democracies had rarely if ever gone to war with each other during this period. Since there were few democracies, often at a distance from each other, it is hardly surprising that their failure to fight each other was little noticed. States need both an opportunity and a willingness²² to go to war with each other. Noncontiguous democracies, unless one or both were great powers, had little opportunity to fight each other. States cannot fight unless they can exert substantial military power against each others' vital territory. Most states, if not great powers with "global reach" (large navies in this era²³) could exert such power only against contiguous states or at least near neighbors. Furthermore, the willingness of states to fight depends in large part on issues over which they have conflicts of interest. Territorial disputes (over borders, or rights of ethnic groups whose presence is common to both) are rare in the absence of proximity.²⁴ Since relatively few of the democracies bordered each other in the 1920s and 1930s,

20. John Maynard Keynes, *The Economic Consequences of the Peace* (London: Macmillan, 1919).

21. Charles Kindleberger, *The World in Depression: 1929–1939* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1973).

22. Benjamin Most and Harvey Starr, *Inquiry, Logic, and International Politics* (Columbia: University of South Carolina Press, 1989).

23. George Modelski and William R. Thompson, *Sea Power in Global Politics, 1494–1993* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1988).

24. Paul F. Diehl and Gary Goertz, *Territorial Changes and International Conflict* (London: Routledge, 1992).

it is not surprising that they generally avoided war with each other. Thus the empirical fact of little or no war between democracies up to this time could be obscured by the predominance of authoritarian states in the international system, and the frequent wars involving one or more such authoritarian states. One could still see the international system as not only anarchic, but in principle threatening the "war of all against all."

Following World War II the situation changed, again, ironically, with a vision of war prevention geared primarily to the last war. The post-World War II era began with the founding of the United Nations, dedicated—as was the League—to the general principle of collective security as carried out by Franklin Roosevelt's "four (ultimately five) policemen" with the power of permanent representatives on the Security Council. But with the Cold War and Soviet-American deadlock in the Security Council arising almost immediately, attention shifted to the more traditional means of collective security through alliance. Despite rhetorical statements like the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and the fact that most—but not all—members of the newly formed North Atlantic Treaty Organization were democracies, democracy was seen more as a binding principle of the Cold War coalition against communism than as a force actively promoting peace among democracies themselves. Moreover, many members of the wider Western alliance system (in Latin America, the Middle East, and Asia) certainly were not democratic.

But by the 1970s, with the increasing numbers of democracies in the international system, the empirical fact of peace among democracies became harder to ignore. There were at one time by various counts thirty-five or so democratic states, and more of them were proximate to one another. Still there was little war, or even serious threats of war, to be found in relationships among those democracies. And more clearly than before, the phenomenon of democratic peace extended beyond the North Atlantic area, and beyond merely the rich industrialized countries belonging to the OECD. The phenomenon began then to be more widely recognized, and by the end of the 1980s it had been widely accepted in the international relations literature, though not so easily explained. This research result is extremely robust, in that by various criteria of war and militarized diplomatic disputes, and various measures of democracy, the relative rarity of violent conflict between democracies still holds up.²⁵ By early 1992

25. This finding is sometimes attributed to Michael Doyle, "Kant, Liberal Legacies, and Foreign Affairs, part 1," *Philosophy and Public Affairs*, Vol. 12, No. 3 (Summer 1983), pp. 205–235; Michael Doyle, "Kant, Liberal Legacies, and Foreign Affairs, part 2," *Philosophy and Public Affairs*, Vol. 12, No. 4 (1983), pp. 323–353; and Michael Doyle, "Liberalism and World Politics," *American Political*

it even had passed into popular political rhetoric, with the international zone of "democratic peace" invoked in speeches by then Secretary of State James Baker and President George Bush, and by Bill Clinton during his presidential campaign.²⁶

Wide recognition is not, however, synonymous with universal acceptance. It became confused with a claim that democracies are *in general*, in dealing with all kinds of states, more peaceful than are authoritarian or other nondemocratically constituted states. This is a much more controversial proposition than "merely" that democracies are peaceful in their dealings with each other, and

Science Review, Vol. 80, No. 4 (December 1986), pp. 1151–1161. The first empirical reports were Dean Babst, "Elective Governments—A Force for Peace," *The Wisconsin Sociologist*, Vol. 3, No. 1 (1964), pp. 9–14; Dean Babst, "A Force for Peace," *Industrial Research* (April 1972), pp. 55–58; Peter Wallensteen, *Structure and War: On International Relations 1820–1968* (Stockholm: Raben & Sjogren, 1973); and Melvin Small and J. David Singer, "The War-Proneness of Democratic Regimes," *Jerusalem Journal of International Relations*, Vol. 1, No. 4 (Summer 1976), pp. 50–69. Early theoretical contributions, later empirical reports, and reviews include R.J. Rummel, *Understanding Conflict and War*, Vol. 2, *The Conflict Helix* (Los Angeles: Sage, 1976); R.J. Rummel, *Understanding Conflict and War*, Vol. 4, *War, Power, and Peace* (Los Angeles: Sage, 1979); R.J. Rummel, *Understanding Conflict and War*, Vol. 5, *The Just Peace* (Los Angeles: Sage, 1981); R.J. Rummel, "Libertarianism and International Violence," *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, Vol. 27, No. 1 (March 1983), pp. 27–71; R.J. Rummel, "A Catastrophe Theory Model of the Conflict Helix, with Tests," *Behavioral Science*, Vol. 32, No. 4 (1987), pp. 241–266; Bruce Russett and Harvey Starr, *World Politics: The Menu for Choice*, 1st ed. (New York: W.H. Freeman, 1981), chap. 15; Steve Chan, "Mirror, Mirror on the Wall . . . Are the Freer Countries More Pacific?" *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, Vol. 28, No. 4 (December 1984), pp. 617–648; Erich Weede, "Democracy and War Involvement," *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, Vol. 28, No. 4 (December 1984), pp. 649–664; Klaus Jürgen Gantzel, "Is Democracy a Guarantor against War-Making Policy?" Working Paper No. 14, University of Hamburg, Institute of Political Science, Center for the Study of Wars, Armaments, and Development, 1987; William Domke, *War and the Changing Global System* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1988); Jean-Baptiste Duroselle, "Western Europe and the Impossible War," *Journal of International Affairs*, Vol. 41, No. 2 (1988), pp. 345–361; Zeev Maoz and Nasrin Abdolali, "Regime Types and International Conflict," *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, Vol. 33, No. 1 (March 1989), pp. 3–35; Francis Fukuyama, "The End of History?" *The National Interest*, Vol. 16, No. 3 (Summer 1989), pp. 3–18; Bruce Russett, *Controlling the Sword: The Democratic Governance of National Security* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1990), chap. 5; Stuart A. Bremer, "Dangerous Dyads: Conditions Affecting the Likelihood of Interstate War, 1816–1965," *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, Vol. 36, No. 2 (1992), pp. 309–341; Bruce Bueno de Mesquita and David Lalman, *War and Reason* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1992); and Zeev Maoz and Bruce Russett, "Alliance, Contiguity, Wealth, and Political Stability: Is the Lack of Conflict between Democracies a Statistical Artifact?" *International Interactions*, Vol. 17, No. 3 (1992), pp. 245–268. James Lee Ray, *Global Politics*, 4th ed. (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1990), p. 240, concurs with Jack S. Levy, "Domestic Politics and War," *Journal of Interdisciplinary History*, Vol. 18, No. 3 (1988), pp. 653–673, that this constitutes "as close as anything we have to an empirical law in international relations"; also see Nils Petter Gleditsch, "Democracy and Peace," *Journal of Peace Research*, Vol. 29, No. 4 (1992), pp. 369–376. For a general statement on the importance of studying international relations at the level of pairs of states, rather than at the state or system level, see Most and Starr, *Inquiry, Logic, and International Politics*.

26. The Baker and Bush statements are quoted in Russett, *Grasping the Democratic Peace*, chapter 6; pp. 127–129. Clinton's emerged prominently in his speech to the Los Angeles World Affairs Council, August 13, 1992, *New York Times*, August 14, 1992, p. A15.

one for which there is little systematic evidence.²⁷ Especially in the Vietnam era of U.S. "imperial overreach," it was a politically charged and widely disbelieved proposition. In that light, both academic observers and policymakers refused to accept even the statement that democracies are peaceful toward each other as a meaningful empirical generalization without some kind of theoretical explanation indicating that it was not merely a coincidence or accident.

Furthermore, some variants of the proposition took the form of statements like "democracies never go to war with each other," or even "democracies never fight each other." The latter statement, applied to relatively low-level lethal violence, is demonstrably wrong as a law-like "never" statement even for the modern international system. The former, limiting the statement to the large-scale and typically sustained form of organized international violence commonly designated as war, nonetheless tempts the historically minded reader to come up with counterexamples. And, especially with the key terms still largely undefined, it is not hard to identify candidate counterexamples.

Democracy, War, and Other Ambiguous Terms

This book will establish the following: First, democratically organized political systems in general operate under restraints that make them more peaceful in their relations with other democracies. Democracies are not necessarily peaceful, however, in their relations with other kinds of political systems. Second, in the modern international system, democracies are less likely to use lethal violence toward other democracies than toward autocratically governed states or than autocratically governed states are toward each other. Furthermore, there are no clearcut cases of sovereign stable democracies waging war with each other in the modern international system. Third, the relationship of rela-

27. Virtually all the authors cited in note 25 agree that democracies are not in general markedly less likely to go to war than are other states. The principal dissenter is Rummel, "Libertarianism and International Violence," and R.J. Rummel, "Libertarian Propositions on Violence within and between Nations," *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, Vol. 27, No. 1 (March 1985), pp. 419-455. But Rummel's empirical analysis ("Libertarianism and International Violence") is limited to 1976-80—a period that omits, among others, the Vietnam War and most post-colonial wars—and his literature review ("Libertarian Propositions on Violence within and between Nations") has been overtaken and corrected by subsequent empirical analyses. Other work, such as Bremer, "Dangerous Dyads," and Stuart A. Bremer, "Are Democracies Less Likely to Join Wars?" paper presented at the annual meeting of the American Political Science Association, Chicago, September 1992, suggests a mixed and still muddy picture; i.e., democracies are less likely to originate wars with all kinds of states, but more likely to join ongoing wars being fought by other states.

tive peace among democracies is importantly a result of some features of democracy, rather than being caused exclusively by economic or geopolitical characteristics correlated with democracy. Exactly what those features are is a matter of theoretical debate, which we shall explore.

At the risk of boring the reader, further discussion requires some conceptual precision. Without it everyone can—and often does—endlessly debate counterexamples while by-passing the phenomenon itself. We need to define what we mean by democracy and war, so as to be able to say just how rare an occasion it is for two democracies to go to war with each other. When we do so it will be evident that those occasions virtually never arise. We then shall spend the rest of the book trying to understand the reasons for that rarity, and its implications for international politics in the post-cold war era.

INTERSTATE WAR

War here means large-scale institutionally organized lethal violence, and to define "large-scale" we shall use the threshold commonly used in the social scientific literature on war: one thousand battle fatalities.²⁸ The figure of one thousand deaths is arbitrary but reasonable. It is meant to eliminate from the category of wars those violent events that might plausibly be ascribed to:

1. "Accident" (e.g., planes that may have strayed across a national boundary by mistake, and been downed).
2. Deliberate actions by local commanders, but not properly authorized by central authorities, as in many border incidents.
3. Limited, local authorized military actions not necessarily intended to progress to large-scale violent conflict but undertaken more as bargaining moves in a crisis, such as military probes intended to demonstrate one's own commitment and to test the resolve of the adversary.
4. Deliberate military actions larger than mere probes, but not substantially resisted by a usually much weaker adversary. The Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia in 1968, which was met with substantial nonviolent resistance but not force of arms and resulted in less than a score of immediate deaths, is such an example, and contrasts with the Soviet invasion of Hungary in 1956, which produced roughly seventeen thousand Hungarian and Soviet dead.

28. Melvin Small and J. David Singer, *Resort to Arms: International and Civil Wars, 1816-1929* (Los Angeles: Sage, 1982).

A threshold of one thousand battle deaths rather neatly cuts off the above kinds of events while leaving largely intact the category of most conflicts that intuitively satisfies the commonsense meaning of war. (Not, of course such rhetorical examples as the "war on poverty" or "war on drugs," or for that matter the boat seizures and very limited exchange of gunfire [no casualties or intent to inflict casualties²⁹] between Britain and Iceland in the 1975 "Cod War" over fishing rights.) It is also convenient that the one thousand-battle-death threshold provides a neat empirical break, with few conflicts between nation states very near it on either side. The most questionable case is probably that between Britain and the Argentine military dictatorship in 1982, over the Falkland Islands/Islands Malvinas. The battle-death count is customarily given as about 950, or just below our numerical threshold. But not to count it would be splitting hairs. It was deliberate, authorized, and involved some fierce land, naval, and air engagements and two invasions (first by Argentina, and then when the British returned to expel the Argentine invaders). It should count as a war, without apology.

The U.K.-Argentine war was unusual in that it inflicted very few civilian casualties. Most wars are not so limited, with civilian deaths frequently far outnumbering those of combatants. Deaths from hunger and disease may also far outnumber battle-inflicted casualties, as surely happened in many nineteenth-century wars and may well have been the case with the Iraqis after Operation Desert Storm. But the number of such deaths may be difficult or impossible to estimate reliably and may be as much a consequence of inadequate medical and public-health capabilities as of military actions. Without minimizing the human consequences of such civilian deaths, it is simply less ambiguous to limit the definition to battle deaths. Similarly, the definition omits wounded and military personnel missing in action, figures commonly included in "casualty" totals but of lower reliability.

A related problem is that of deciding which political units are to be listed as fighting in a war. Sometimes in coalition warfare most or all of the deaths in a particular coalition will be borne by one or a few members with other members formally but not practically engaged in combat. For the latter, especially in circumstances where a nominal combatant suffers few or no identifiable deaths, it seems forced to include it among war participants. Small and Singer use a criterion requiring a state either to commit at least one thousand

29. William Mark Habeeb, *Power and Tactics in International Negotiations: How Weak Nations Bargain with Strong Nations* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1988), chap. 6.

troops to battle, or to suffer at least one hundred battle fatalities, in order to count as a participant.³⁰

This definition also excludes, on theoretical grounds, covert actions in which one government secretly undertakes activities, including the use of lethal violence and the support of violent actors within the other government's territory, either to coerce or to overthrow that government. Such activities may not involve deaths on the scale of "wars," and when they do the foreign intervention is by its very covert nature hard to document (though one can often, if perhaps belatedly, discover the metaphoric "smoking gun"). But these activities, precisely because they are denied at the time by the government that undertakes them, imply very different political processes than does a war publicly and officially undertaken. Because they may be undertaken under circumstances when overt war is not acceptable they will, however, receive attention at a later point in the book.

For purposes of theoretical precision in argument yet another qualification is required, and that is a definition of "interstate" war. Here that term means war between sovereign "states" internationally recognized as such by other states, including by major powers whose recognition of a government typically confers de facto statehood. Some such definition focusing on organized independent states is common in the social science literature, and is important for the analysis of this book. It is meant to exclude those "colonial" wars fought for the acquisition of territory inhabited by "primitive" people without recognized states, as practiced by nineteenth-century imperialism, or for the twentieth-century liberation of those people. War it may certainly be, but interstate it is not unless or until both sides are generally recognized as having the attributes of statehood. Applying this definition may well display a Western cultural bias, but it is appropriate to the behavior of states which, in the period, also are defined as "democratic" by the admittedly Western standards spelled out below. Nonstate participants would not meet those standards.

Wars of liberation—with one or both parties not yet recognized as a state—are in this respect similar to those civil wars in which one or both parties to the conflict fights precisely so as to be free of sharing statehood with the other. Such wars are fought to escape from the coercive institutions of a common state, and to include them would confuse rather than clarify the generalization that democracies rarely go to war with each other. As will be clear in the next chapter, a crucial element in that generalization often depends upon the role

30. Small and Singer, *Resort to Arms*, chap. 4.

of democratic institutions and practices in promoting peaceful conflict resolution within states. Intrastate conflicts that become so fierce that lethal violence is common often indicate that the institutions of the state have become the problem rather than the solution. For example, the United Kingdom and the Republic of Ireland have lived in peace with each other, as separate states, since 1922; the conflict in Northern Ireland arises precisely because many people there emphatically do not wish to be governed as part of the existing common political structure. Democracies are only slightly less likely than other kinds of states to experience civil war.³¹

DEMOCRACY

For modern states, democracy (or polyarchy, following Dahl³²) is usually identified with a voting franchise for a substantial fraction of citizens, a government brought to power in contested elections, and an executive either popularly elected or responsible to an elected legislature, often also with requirements for civil liberties such as free speech.³³ Huntington uses very similar criteria of "a twentieth-century political system as democratic to the extent that its most powerful collective decision makers are selected through fair, honest, and periodic elections in which candidates freely compete for votes and in which virtually all the adult population is eligible to vote."³⁴ In addition, he identifies a free election for transfer of power from a nondemocratic government as "the critical point in the process of democratization." Ray similarly requires that the possibility for the leaders of the government to be defeated in an election and replaced has been demonstrated by historical precedent.³⁵

A simple dichotomy between democracy and autocracy of course hides real shades of difference, and mixed systems that share features of both. Moreover, the precise application of these terms is to some degree culturally and temporally dependent. As we shall see, democracy did not mean quite the same to

31. Bremer, "Are Democracies Less Likely to Join Wars?"

32. Robert A. Dahl, *Polyarchy: Participation and Opposition* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1971).

33. With some variations in the mix and in the precise empirical applications, these elements are common in the cross-national literature. By the middle to late twentieth century the requirement for a responsible executive becomes largely redundant to the other conditions; see Tatu Vanhanen, *The Process of Democratization: A Comparative Study of 147 States, 1980-88* (New York: Crane Russak, 1990), but it certainly is not for the nineteenth century. A good measurement is Richard L. Merritt and Dina A. Zinnes, "Democracies and War," in Alex Inkeles, ed., *On Measuring Democracy: Its Consequences and Concomitants* (New Brunswick, N.J.: Transaction, 1991), pp. 207-234.

34. Samuel P. Huntington, *The Third Wave: Democratization in the Late Twentieth Century* (Norman: University of Oklahoma Press, 1991), pp. 7, 9.

35. James Lee Ray, "Wars between Democracies: Rare or Non-Existent?" *International Interactions*, Vol. 18, No. 3 (1993), pp. 251-276.

the ancient Greeks as it does to people of the late twentieth century. Even in the modern era the yardstick has been rubbery. Nineteenth century democracies often had property qualifications for the vote and typically excluded women, while the United States—democratic by virtually any standard of the day—disenfranchised blacks. Britain, with its royal prerogatives, rotten boroughs, and very restricted franchise before the Reform Act of 1832, hardly could be counted as a democracy. Even that reform brought voting rights to less than one-fifth of adult males, so one might reasonably withhold the "democracy" designation until after the Second Reform Act of 1867, or even until the secret ballot was introduced in 1872. By then, at the latest, Britain took its place with the relatively few other states commonly characterized as democratic in the parlance of the era. But if, before the late nineteenth century, we admit countries with as few as 10 percent of all adults eligible to vote as democratic (a criterion used by Small and Singer³⁶; Doyle uses a cutoff of 30 percent of all males³⁷), by the middle to late twentieth century nothing less than a substantially universal franchise will suffice.

The term "contested elections" admits similar ambiguities, but in practice it has come to require two or more legally recognized parties. States with significant prerogatives in military and foreign affairs for nonelected agents (e.g., monarchs) should be excluded as having nonresponsible executives, even in the nineteenth century.

By the middle to late twentieth century the matter of guaranteed and respected civil rights, including rights to political organization and political expression, also become a key element in any commonsense definition of democracy.³⁸ The exercise of such civil rights tends to be highly correlated with the existence of democratic institutions as just elaborated, but not perfectly so. The institutions may be found without the regular widespread exercise of the rights; the opposite (civil liberties assured, but not democratic institutions) is rarer. For purposes of the discussion here we will nevertheless not use civil liberties per se as a defining quality, and we shall also ignore the matter of free-market economic liberties. While there is very likely a causal nexus between economic liberties and secure political freedom, the relationship is complex and, unlike some authors,³⁹ I will not build it into the definition.

36. Small and Singer, "The War-Prone-ness of Democratic Regimes."

37. Doyle, "Kant, Liberal Legacies, and Foreign Affairs, part 1."

38. Robert A. Dahl, *Democracy and Its Critics* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1989).

39. Rummel, "Libertarianism and International Violence"; and Doyle, "Kant, Liberal Legacies, and Foreign Affairs, part 1."

In not including civil rights and economic liberty as defining qualities of democracy we are lowering the standards by which a country can be labeled a democracy. That is highly relevant to our next topic, an examination of conflicts alleged by some scholars to be wars between democracies. By lowering the standards we are making it more likely that some events will be labeled wars between democracies—events that I and many other writers contend are, a most, exceedingly rare.

Theoretical precision, however, requires one further qualification: some rather minimal stability or longevity. Huntington emphasizes stability or institutionalization as "a central dimension in the analysis of any political system."⁴⁰ To count a war as one waged by a democracy Doyle requires that representative government be in existence for at least three years prior to the war.⁴¹ Perhaps that is a bit too long, yet some period must have elapsed during which democratic processes and institutions could become established, so that both the citizens of the "democratic" state and its adversary could regard it as one governed by democratic principles. Most of the doubtful cases arise within a single year of the establishment of democratic government.

By application of these criteria it is impossible to identify unambiguously any wars between democratic states in the period since 1815. A few close calls exist, in which some relaxation of the criteria could produce such a case. But to have no clearcut cases, out of approximately 71 interstate wars involving a total of nearly 270 participants, is impressive. Even these numbers are deceptively low as representing total possibilities. For example, as listed by Small and Singer, 21 states count as participating on the Allied Side in World War II, with 8 on the Axis side.⁴² Thus in that war alone there were 168 pairs of warring states. Allowing for other multilateral wars, approximately 500 pairs of states went to war against each other in the period. Of these, fewer than a handful can with any plausibility at all be considered candidates for exceptions to a generalization that democracies do not fight each other.

Some Alleged Wars between Democracies

To see what these criteria produce, consider the list in Table 1.1 of wars that have sometimes been suggested as exceptions to the generalization that democracies do not go to war with each other.

40. Huntington, *The Third Wave*, p. 11.

41. Doyle, "Kant, Liberal Legacies, and Foreign Affairs, part 1."

42. Small and Singer, *Resort to Arms*.

Table 1.1 Some "Candidate" Wars between Democracies.

War of 1812, U.S. and Great Britain
Roman Republic (Papal States) vs. France, 1849
American Civil War, 1861
Ecuador-Colombia, 1863
Franco-Prussian War, 1870
Boer War, 1899
Spanish-American War, 1898
Second Philippine War, 1899
World War I, Imperial Germany vs. western democracies 1914/17
World War II, Finland vs. western democracies 1941
Lebanon vs. Israel, 1948
Lebanon vs. Israel, 1967

Four should be dismissed because they fall outside the criteria established even for any kind of interstate war in the period. The first, the War of 1812, is easy to dismiss simply because it precedes the beginning date—1815—of the best-known compilation of all wars.⁴³ That may seem like a cheap and arbitrary escape, but it is not. There simply were very few democracies in the international system before that date, and as we discussed with the British case above, though Britain had moved quite far from royal absolutism it just did not fit the criteria either of suffrage or of fully responsible executive.

The American Civil War and the Second Philippine War are also readily eliminated as plausible candidates by straightforward use of the definitions. Whatever it may be called below the Mason-Dixon line, the Civil War is rightly named, in that the Confederacy never gained international recognition of its sovereignty; as a war for separation or to prevent separation it comes under our rubric of wars induced by the frictions of sharing common statehood. The Philippine War of 1899 was a colonial war, in which the United States was trying to solidify control of a former Spanish colony it had acquired. The Philippine resistance constituted an authentic war of resistance against colonialism, but not on the part of an elected democratic government. This is not in any way to denigrate the resistance, but merely to insist on a distinction that will be important throughout the book: especially by the standards of Western ethnocentric attitudes at the time, the Philippine resistance was not widely regarded as "democratic" in a way that would induce either normative or institutional constraints on the United States.

43. Ibid.

The Boer War, begun in 1899, also fails to fit the requirements for an interstate war. Small and Singer identify it as an extrasystemic war because the South African Republic—by far the larger of the two Boer combatants, the other being the Orange Free State—was not generally recognized as an independent state.⁴⁴ Britain recognized only its internal sovereignty, retaining suzerainty and requiring it to submit all treaties to the British government for approval. This, too, is properly an unsuccessful war for independence. Moreover, the two Boer republics strained the definition of democracy, then as for almost a century subsequently. Not only was suffrage restricted to the white male minority (roughly 10 percent of the adult population) in the South African Republic, but the electorate was further reduced, perhaps by half, by a property qualification and long-term residence requirements.⁴⁵

Two other conflicts can be dismissed because they fall short of the casualty levels required for a "war." These are Finland's participation in World War II on the "wrong" side and Lebanon's involvement in the Six-Day War of 1967. Finland was actively at war only with the Soviet Union, in an attempt to wrest back the territory taken from it in the Winter War of 1939–40. Although it was nominally at war with the Western allies, there is no record of combat or casualties between Finland and democratic states that would even approach the rather low threshold specified above. In the Six-Day War of 1967 Lebanon (then still an at least marginally democratic state, as it was not when invaded by Israel in 1982) participated in "combat" only by sending a few aircraft into Israeli airspace; the planes were driven back with, apparently, no casualties at all.

In the remaining six cases one or both of the participants fails the test for democracy. Lebanon's participation in the 1948 war was well above the criterion used for a belligerent. Israel, however, had not previously been independent, and had not yet held a national election. While the authenticity of Israel's national leadership was hardly in question, Lebanon—itself not fully democratic—could not have been expected to accredit it as a democratic state.

44. *Ibid.*

45. Robert Lacour-Gayet, *A History of South Africa* (New York: Hastings House, 1978), pp. 168, 170, 182, 194. Robert L. Rotberg, *Suffer the Future: Policy Choices in Southern Africa* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1980), p. 30, further reports that voters had to be "approved by the elders of the Dutch Reformed Church," but the constitutional provision requiring a voter to be a member of the church was repealed immediately after its passage in 1858. See G.W. Eybers, *Select Constitutional Documents Illuminating South African History, 1795–1910* (London: Routledge, 1918), pp. 368–369.

The 1863 war between Ecuador and Colombia also fits the criteria for war, but neither regime meets any reasonable requirement for democratic stability. Both governments came to power through revolution. Colombia's president governed with a new federal constitution promulgated only in May 1863; Ecuador's Gabriel García Moreno became president two years earlier, but is described as heading an "autocratic regime"⁴⁶ and governing "with absolute authority."⁴⁷ As for France against the Roman Republic, both parties were but ephemerally democratic. Following the revolution of early 1848, presidential elections took place under the new French constitution only in December of that year. The notion of a democratic Papal States sounds oxymoronic. The pope introduced a constitution with an elective council of deputies in 1848, but reserved veto power to himself and the College of Cardinals. After an insurrection in November, he fled and the Roman Republic was proclaimed in February 1849. Within two months the republic was at war with France.

The Franco-Prussian War can be eliminated simply by looking at France. Reforms ratified in the plebiscite of May 1870 could be interpreted as making the empire into a constitutional monarchy, but war began a mere two months later. In Prussia/Germany the emperor appointed and could dismiss the chancellor; a defeat in the Reichstag did not remove the chancellor from office. The emperor's direct authority over the army and foreign policy deprives the state of the democratic criterion of "responsible executive" on war and peace matters; Volker Berghahn calls the constitutional position of the monarchy "almost absolutist."⁴⁸ Doyle rightly excludes Imperial Germany from his list of liberal states.⁴⁹ Such a decision removes World War I from the candidate list.

The most difficult case is the Spanish-American War of 1898. Spain after 1890 had universal male suffrage, and a bicameral legislature with an executive nominally responsible to it. But the reality was more complex. The ministry was selected by the king, who thus remained the effective ruler of the state. Nominally competitive elections were really manipulated by a process known as *caciquismo*. By mutual agreement, the Liberal and Conservative parties rotated in office; governmental changes preceded rather than followed elections. Through extensive corruption and administration procedures the king and politicians in Madrid controlled the selection of parliamentary candidates and their election. Election results were often published in the press before

46. George C. Kohn, *Dictionary of Wars* (Garden City, N.Y.: Doubleday, 1986), p. 150.

47. William L. Langer, *An Encyclopedia of World History* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1972), p. 852.

48. Volker Berghahn, *Germany and the Approach of War in 1914* (New York: St. Martin's, 1973), p. 9.

49. Doyle, "Kant, Liberal Legacies, and Foreign Affairs, part 1."

polling day. The meaningless elections were thus manipulated by the king and his close advisers; the system lacked the democratic quality of a responsible executive.⁵⁰ Ernest May describes the system as "preserving the appearance of a parliamentary democracy with none of its suspected dangers."⁵¹ None of the published large-scale analyses of the question of democracies fighting each other puts Spain among the democratic countries⁵² nor do most major long-term political surveys.⁵³

It seems, therefore, best to treat it as a close call but probably not a refutation even of the strong statement that democracies *never* make war on each other. Equally important, as we shall see later in the book, is the matter of perceptions. The Spanish political situation was at best marginal enough that key United States decisionmakers could readily persuade themselves and their audiences that it was not democratic. Consider, for example, the remarks of the two Republican senators from Massachusetts. Senator Henry Cabot Lodge: "We are there because we represent the spirit of liberty and the spirit of the new time, and Spain is over against us because she is mediaeval, cruel, dying." Senator George Hoar: "The results of a great war [on which the U.S. was embarking] are due to the policy of the king and the noble and the tyrant, not the policy of the people."⁵⁴

Subsequent to my writing the above, Ray has presented a thorough review of these and other alleged cases of wars between democracies, and concludes that the generalization of no wars between democracies remains true.⁵⁵ Whether or not one holds to the lawlike "never" statement may not really be very important. Almost all of the few near misses are in the nineteenth century. Since that was an era of generally very imperfect democracy by modern criteria, it is no surprise to find most of the near misses then.

Depending on the precise criteria, only twelve to fifteen states qualified as democracies at the end of the nineteenth century. The empirical significance of

the rarity of war between democracies emerges only in the first half of the twentieth century, with at least twice the number of democracies as earlier, and especially with the existence of perhaps sixty democracies by the mid-1980s. Since the statistical likelihood of war between democracies is related to the number of pairs of democracies, the contrast between the two centuries is striking: by a very loose definition, possibly three or four wars out of roughly sixty pairs before 1900, and at most one or two out of about eighteen hundred pairs thereafter.⁵⁶ As twentieth-century politics unfold, the phenomenon of war between democracies becomes impossible or almost impossible to find.

Even with the differing definitions of democracy and of war, this generalization is exceedingly robust. Long-term rival states, with many conflicts of interest between them, have gone to war or had substantial fatal clashes only when one or both of them was not governed democratically. For example, in the case of the Greek-Turkish dispute over Cyprus, by far the worst violence erupted in 1974 under the most dictatorial government either country experienced since 1945, when the Greek colonels overthrew the elected Cypriot government of Archbishop Makarios. Faced with the prospect of forcible *enosis* between Greece and Cyprus, Turkey replied by invading the island and occupying nearly a third of its territory. By contrast, the 1963-64 clashes—when democratic Greek and Turkish governments supported their protégés during outbreaks on the islands—were much more easily contained, largely by an American warning and UN peacekeeping action. And confrontations later in the 1970s, between democratic governments, were restrained short of any fatalities.⁵⁷ India and Pakistan have of course fought repeatedly and sometimes bloodily during their history as independent states. Yet no fatalities are recorded in disputes between them during Pakistan's most democratic periods of 1962-64 and 1988-92.⁵⁸

Even the kind of crisis bargaining that uses military force in a threatening manner becomes, in the twentieth century, rare between democracies, even if

50. Raymond Carr, *Modern Spain 1875-1980* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1980), pp. 10-15.

51. Ernest R. May, *Imperial Democracy: The Emergence of America as a Great Power* (New York: Harcourt, Brace & World, 1961), p. 97.

52. Small and Singer, "The War-Proneness of Democratic Regimes"; Doyle, "Kant, Liberal Legacies, and Foreign Affairs, part 1"; Chan, "Mirror, Mirror on the Wall"; Maoz and Abdolali, "Regime Types and International Conflict"; and Bremer, "Dangerous Dyads."

53. Tatu Vanhanen, *The Emergence of Democracy: A Comparative Study of 119 States, 1850-1979* (Helsinki: Finnish Society of Sciences and Letters, 1984), Arthur S. Banks, *Cross-Polity Time-Series Data* (Cambridge, Mass.: MIT Press, 1971), and Ted Robert Gurr, Keith Jagers, and Will Moore, *Polity II Handbook* (Boulder: University of Colorado Press, 1989), code it as sharing democratic and autocratic characteristics.

54. *Congressional Record*, April 13, 1898, p. 3783; and *Congressional Record*, April 14, 1898, p. 3831.

55. Ray, "Wars between Democracies."

56. The formula for calculating the number of possible pairs is $N(N-1)/2$. Systematic statistical analyses appear in *Grasping the Democratic Peace*. The data here and for Table 1.2 are from the compilation of Militarized International Disputes discussed in chapter 4 of *Grasping the Democratic Peace*.

57. Kyriacos Markides, *The Rise and Fall of the Cyprus Republic* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1977); Dankwart A. Rustow, *Turkey: America's Forgotten Ally* (New York: Council on Foreign Relations, 1987); and Montague Stearns, ed., *Entangled Allies: U.S. Policy toward Greece, Turkey, and Cyprus* (New York: Council on Foreign Relations, 1992).

58. S.M. Burke, *Pakistan's Foreign Policy: An Historical Analysis* (London: Oxford University Press, 1973); Raju C. Thomas, *Indian Security Policy* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1986); and Herbert K. Tillema, *International Conflict Since 1945: A Bibliographic Handbook of Wars and Military Interventions* (Boulder, Colo.: Westview Press, 1991).

Table 1.2. Dispute Behavior of Politically Relevant Interstate Dyads, 1946–1986.

Highest Level of Dispute	Both States Democratic	One or Both Nondemocratic	Total Dyads
No dispute	3,864	24,503	28,367
Threat of force	2	39	41
Display of force	4	116	120
Use of force	8	513	521
War	0	32	32
Totals	3,878	25,203	29,081
Escalation Probabilities			
To threat of force	0.05%	0.16%	
To display of force	85.7%	94.4%	
To use of force	57.1%	77.9%	
To war	0.0%	4.6%	

SOURCES: See chapter 4 for sources and definitions.

not quite absent. And if there is crisis bargaining, it does not escalate to the point of war.

Table 1.2 illustrates these facts in data on all militarized diplomatic disputes over the period from 1946 to 1986. "Dyad" means a pair of states; for the table we count each year of existence separately, thus Britain and France in 1946 constitute one observation, and another in 1947. The highest level of conflict reached in the dispute between that pair of states is identified. (Disputes that spill over into two or more years are counted only in the year they began or were escalated to a higher level.) The phrase "politically relevant dyads" refers to all pairs of states that are contiguous or at least fairly close to each other, or where one of the states in the pair is a major power and hence has military "global reach." This recognizes, as noted above, that the majority of states in the international system lack the means or the interest to engage in militarized disputes with each other, and hence are irrelevant to a serious analysis. Further information on definitions and sources can be postponed for much more detailed analysis in chapter 4.

The information in this simple table has several rich theoretical implications, and we shall return to it in subsequent chapters. There were no wars between democracies, and even though the number of democratic dyads is relatively small, if they had fought wars as frequently with each other as one finds in the second column, there would have been five wars between democracies. Note also that in this period there were only fourteen instances of disputing pairs involving the threat, display, or use of military force by one democracy against

another. The odds that any pair of politically relevant democratic states would have a militarized dispute, at any level, in a year during this period were only 1 in 276. By contrast, if one or both states in the pair was not a democracy, the odds were as short as 1 in 36—eight times greater. Surely this is a very dramatic difference in behavior. The actual use of military force involved trivial occasions like the "Cod War"; very minor fire by Israel against Britain during the 1956 Suez intervention, in which the British and Israelis were in fact accomplices; brief conflict between British and Turkish forces during a 1963 peacekeeping operation on Cyprus; and Turkish sinking of a Greek boat in 1978.

One can also use the tabular information to calculate "escalation probabilities" for militarized disputes that do occur. For democracies, the chances that any militarized dispute would progress up the scale of force were consistently lower, at every level, than for pairs in which one or both states were not democracies. For example, only a little more than half of the few disputes between democracies resulted in the actual use of force, whereas nearly 80 percent of all disputes by other kinds of pairs of states escalated at least to the use of force. For earlier periods (the nineteenth century, and 1900–1945) the relationships for conflict-proneness and escalation appear to be in the same direction—democratic pairs of states dispute less—but much weaker than in the post-1945 era.⁵⁹

It is tempting to believe that a norm against the use of force between democracies, and even the threat of use of force, has emerged and strengthened over time. To pursue the matter of norms, however, becomes a subject for much further analysis. The emergence of norms against democracies fighting each other is traceable, and by many theories it did indeed become a powerful restraint. Other theories, however, attribute the relative absence of lethal violence between democracies to many other influences. The next chapter lays out these partly competing, partly complementary theories in detail.

59. Maoz and Abdolali, "Regime Types and International Conflict"; and Bremer, "Dangerous Dyads."